Dancing Grounds: Developing New Orleans' Artistic Changemakers

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This interview was conducted with Jess Eugene, Youth Programs Manager of Dancing Grounds.

Founded in 2012 by Laura Stein and Jessica Donley, Dancing Grounds was born from a shared vision to unite the local dance community and provide high-quality, accessible dance programming in New Orleans. The organization began in Laura's Bywater home, where she transformed her living room into a dance studio, her kitchen into an art gallery, and her backyard into a performance space. As demand for classes grew, Stein and Donley partnered with a local property developer to create a state-of-the-art dance facility featuring two studios for classes and performances, which officially opened in March 2014.

Their mission to develop young leaders, promote health and wellness, and advocate for social change through inclusive and accessible dance programs that reach New Orleans residents of all ages has always held strong. Their flagship initiative, Dance for Social Change, inspires New Orleans youth to use their artistic talents to catalyze positive social change in their communities. Since 2012, Dancing Grounds has reached over 9,000 young people and 12,000 adults through its unique programming that highlights its values of equity and racial justice, space and place, integrity and accountability, relationships and organizing, and abundance and joy.

Q: Twenty years after Katrina, what does Dancing Grounds' existence say about New Orleans' resilience and the community's ability to rebuild on its own terms?

Jess Eugene: "I think the story of how Dancing Grounds came to be is very reminiscent of New Orleans culture. There's this issue, or there's this thing I wish I had; let me make it happen. Our co-founder, Laura, had been in New Orleans for a while and realized that she wanted to dance and specifically dance with other adults. So, quite literally, she rounded up a few friends and was like, 'Let's go, let's dance in my living room.' When I think about New Orleans folks, I'm always thinking about the potholes and how they are huge in the city, sometimes being there for years. And how folks around New Orleans have just started putting oyster shells in the potholes so people aren't totaling their cars. That sort of energy, the scrappy nature of the city, the kind that says, since this thing has never been handled, let me do it myself."

Q: Katrina displaced so many families and disrupted entire communities. How does your work help repair or strengthen what was lost?

JE: "Part of our work with young people is not just teaching them dance, but we're also teaching them about community. We're teaching them about social resistance and the holistic perspective of dance and its connection to social justice work. So in the next 20 years, I hope we will see some of Dancing Grounds' young people become the changemakers and culture bearers in our city. Go from being students in our program to becoming a board chair for another nonprofit organization, working for social change. Or even creating organizations that are addressing social issues or gaps in our communities that we might not even be aware of right now,"

Q: There are a lot of forces pulling people, especially young people, away from New Orleans. How does your work give people a reason to stay and invest in this city?

JE: "I do believe we do a really good job of maintaining relationships with our young people. Even as they become adults, we encourage them to take a journey away from the city, but then to come back. A lot of our alumni, specifically from our Dance for Social Change teen company, go off to college, and then we see them return in the summertime. They know there are positions available to work with our youth programs as TAs, receptionists, and there are other opportunities as well.

We're intentional about making sure there is space for them, continuing to connect with them, and asking, what do you want? What are your goals and aspirations? Sometimes our understanding can be limited, and young people might believe they can only be successful, especially in dance, if they leave the city. There is a little bit of truth to that, but it's not the end-all, be-all. We try to offer different perspectives on how they can still do what they want here and stay connected to the city. We have folks on our staff who, even while living in New Orleans, are still very plugged in. They've performed with artists like Solange and Kendrick Lamar. There are more opportunities than people often realize. So it's really about making sure that knowledge is shared."

Q: What keeps you going on the days when the work feels impossible, and what does that tell you about why this organization needs to exist?

JE: "I think the young people are always my number one; this is who my work is impacting. From our three-year-olds to our 18-year-olds, that's a lot of young people and families we engage with every year. So, what keeps me going is knowing that the work we do can truly impact a young person's life. Dance and the arts help young people beyond just performance; dance supports academics, confidence, and growth. So even if our students don't become professional dancers, what they're learning at Dancing Grounds still carries real weight.

The same goes for families. If affordability is a barrier, it's important to me that we still create space for that young person, because I understand how powerful access to dance can be. Really, it's thinking about that impact that keeps me grounded and reminds me why this work matters."

Q: When you think about the next 20 years, what role do you see Dancing Grounds playing in the continued recovery and reimaging of New Orleans?

JE: Dance throughout the United States is really seen as a high art form. Where things like ballet and modern are seen as the height of dance, the most essential forms of dance. And so what does that mean for people of color? A lot of us tend to feel left out of the conversation or ostracized, made to be othered. So for us at Dancing Grounds, it's important that we not only teach the fundamentals of ballet and modern, but also elevate the dance forms that are culturally relevant to our city. For us, that means always having classes that center the experiences of people of color, like hip-hop, afro grooves, and salsa fit. This allows us to create spaces in this part of New Orleans that may not have existed or weren't present pre-Katrina. Within that, we are taking all these Black and Brown children from this community with us so they can gain this high-quality, accessible, and affordable dance education.

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Your support makes this work possible. A gift of any size helps Dancing Grounds continue serving the community and building a stronger, more resilient city for everyone.

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